

Toy theatre casting Victorian boys as theatre managers

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The following analysis is based on a sample of 21 Victorian experiences of toy theatre recorded in published articles and book chapters that I could access online. It is available in the accompanying dataset available on [Google Spreadsheets](#) and deposited in Zenodo.

Nearing his sixties, Bohemian playwright and translator John Oxenford (1812–1877) reminisced, for the theatrical annual *The Era Almanack*, about a hobby from his boyhood: toy theatre. Cutting out theatrical prints of actors in character and pasting them on cardboard to enact scenes in a table-top theatre was a popular, albeit now mostly forgotten, pastime for well-to-do children throughout much of the nineteenth century in Britain. As attested by Oxenford when he speaks of “a British boy *manag[ing]* a Toy Theatre” (68, emphasis added), juvenile drama did not cast the child as a front-of-house star, but as a theatre manager. In fact, none of the accounts speak of “playing” with a toy theatre, a word that would apply both to a toy or to a character: they speak of being a “proud possessor” (Plowman 200), a “proprietor” (Oxenford 67), or a “manager” (Archer 105; Arthur 44-45; Oxenford 67). Carrying on with the terminology of business and entrepreneurship, the child could have a “partner” or “associates.”

The managerial approach is tied to adulthood, but also to masculinity. Nearing his sixties, Oxenford couches the gendered roles of toy theatre in a very patriarchal light:

The young ladies of the family might assist with their scissors or their camel’s hair pencil, and the children might gape, as the growing wonder matured to perfection before their eyes; but in a well-regulated household the manager and proprietor was always a boy, beginning to think himself a man. (67)

Being “a man” is contrasted with the age of the “children” and the gender of the “young ladies” assisting the “manager and proprietor.” The much younger William Archer (1856–1924), a Scottish critic and translator, writing a decade and a half after Oxenford, has a very different take on gender in tinselling. He claims the pastime attracted “the youth of both sexes” (143), crediting girls with improving the quality of the tinselled

works by inserting fabrics to enliven costumes. Oxenford's claim that "the manager and proprietor was always a boy" (67) is further challenged by the fact that the girl who grew up to become actress Ellen Terry owned a "Redington's Theatre" (3). Girls could also be attracted to the stage by ways of its miniature version.

Of the people connected to the theatre in their adult life whose experiences with the toy version were recorded, most did not hold front-of-house functions like Terry but were backstage personnel or theatre critics. Juvenile drama, being a form of puppetry, might have lent itself more to those positions than to seeking the spotlight. Children's literature scholar Suzanne Rahn summarizes the different levels of participation toy theatre afforded:

Some children, like [Robert Louis] Stevenson, might find sufficient stimulus in studying titles and printed sheets and perhaps coloring the scenes and characters. Others might need to cut out and arrange the figures, or even to attempt production of the play. Still other children might create their own plays (32-33).

The first and last of these levels of engagement are linked to very specific individuals and appeared only once in the sample. I have argued elsewhere that the capacities of Stevenson's imagination were uncommonly vast and that his experience reading penny dreadfuls in shop windows cannot simply be generalized to other children (Léger-St-Jean, 2016). The same applies to his experience sampling juvenile drama sheets at the store (Stevenson 227-228). The last example refers to theatrical manager and impresario Sir Charles Blake Cochran (1872-1951) and Aubrey Beardsley (1872-1898). They met at school and "discarded the published 'sheets'" in favour of dramas "concocted" by themselves (Cochran 8). The mid-level type of engagement that involved cutting-and-pasting the characters was better represented in the sample, warranting fuller investigation.

Toy theatre projects took up a great quantity of time, often in the winter, and involved a great many steps that introduced children to the work of backstage personnel. The two most detailed, step-by-step accounts of what one did with a miniature stage are by Theo Arthur and Edward Draper (1827-1899). The former writes in 1891 about the 1830s, 1840s, and 1850s. Draper and Arthur were thus probably born around the same time. In Draper's account, there was (a) "the preliminary saving of the pocket-money;" (b) "the

purchase or construction of the theatre;" (c) "the colouring, pasting down, and cutting out of the characters;" (d) the painting of the scenes; and (e) the "performance on the parlour-table before an admiring party" (182). Arthur suggests the audience would have consisted of "sisters, cousins, aunts, and schoolfellows" (44). As theatre historian Catherine Hindson put it, speaking of tinselling and grangerizing (or extra-illustration), it is a "domestic customisation of a commercially produced object" (197). Her expression aptly brings together the two sites of excitement and activity: the shop, where the prints are bought, and the home, where they are done up. Toy theatre was thus not only a miniature version of a stage, but also a scaled-down version of staging a play, from financing to attracting audiences.

Of particular significance were the roles of wardrobe and scene designers (now known as costume and set designers), through the coloring of the characters and scenes, and stage mechanics, in performing the special effects. Regarding the first two functions, they were a source of pleasure rather than a bore, if Theo Arthur's pronouncement is to be believed: "no juvenile manager with any self-respect ever through of allowing himself to be deprived of half his pleasure by having 'the painting' done for him" (45). As for the role of stage mechanic, Cochran provides the most vivid description when he describes how his miniature stage caught fire during a staging of *The Miller and his Men*:

In working up the climax, with revolving mill, red fire, and so on, I felt the lack of four or more hands. Pushing on a character in a tin slide, lighting the red fire, manipulating a trap and working the wheel, while at the same time speaking the lines of the characters, made me lose my presence of mind (Cochran 7).

During the performance, the young puppeteer must be all at once acting manager ("[p]ushing on a character in a tin slide"), stage mechanic ("lighting the red fire, manipulating a trap and working the wheel"), and actor ("speaking the lines of the characters"), and it proved too much for many. According to Charles Dickens's eldest son, the preparations brought greater pleasure than "the ultimate performances" (526). Sir Cochran, who did grow up to become a theatrical manager, concurs: "the pleasure of the toy theatre was in anticipation rather than in realization" (Cochran 8-9). The elaborate puppetry skills required in the performance might have contributed in making the backstage work of wardrobe and scene design more attractive in toy theatre.

Works cited

Primary sources

See the “Experiences” table in the dataset available on [Google Spreadsheets](#) and deposited in Zenodo.

Secondary sources

Hindson, Catherine. “Grangerizing Theatre’s Histories: Spectatorship, the Theatrical Tinsel Picture and the Grangerized Book.” *Nineteenth Century Theatre and Film*, vol. 42, no. 2, Nov. 2015, p. 195-210.

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Rahn, Suzanne. “Wild Models of the World: The Lure of the Toy Theater.” *Rediscoveries in Children’s Literature*, Garland, 1995, p. 23-37.